

The Noble Great Secret Tantra of Acala (the Immovable One)

Ārya Acala Mahāguhya Tantra · Toh 434 · Derge Kangyur

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The Noble Great Secret Tantra of Acala, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Acala Mahāguhya Tantra and in Tibetan as the Phakpa Mi Yowa'i Sang Gyü Chenpo, is a Vajrayāna tantric scripture centered on Acala (the Immovable One), a wrathful deity closely associated with Mañjuśrī and the purification of obstacles. The text belongs to the class of tantric literature and takes the form of a tantra spoken by the great Vairocana, presenting teachings on maṇḍala arrangement and esoteric practice within an assembly of bodhisattvas and vajra-holders dwelling in the realm of Akaniṣṭha. It is Toh 434 in the Kangyur, classified among the tantric texts of that collection.

This completes the fifth chapter, the chapter on the arrangement of the maṇḍala arising from the permanence of the noble Acala.

In the language of India: Ārya Acala Mahāguhya Tantra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Secret Tantra of Acala (the Immovable One). Homage to the noble Mañjuśrī in his youthful form.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One, the great Vairocana, dwelling in the realm of Akaniṣṭha, entered into the meditative absorption called "Greatly Joyful and Vanquisher of Māra." At that time the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī in his youthful form, Vajradharma, Vajrapāṇi, the one who turns the wheel of Dharma immediately upon arousing the awakening mind, Vajrayakṣa, Vajramuṣṭi, and so forth — a measureless assembly of those filled with great joy — were present together. Then the Blessed One uttered "Vajra rakṣa rakṣaṃ hūṃ," and by means of wrathful vajra-beings sealed all the directions and intermediate directions.

Striving diligently for the sake of protection,
He destroyed the preparations of the obstructors.
Hūṃ phaṭ.

Then the Blessed One uttered "hām," and from his own heart he summoned forth Acala, King of the Wrathful Ones:

In his right hand a sword, in his left the threatening gesture,
Dark as a rain cloud, intensely black,
Perfectly adorned with serpents and skulls.
Acala bestows his blessing,
And from the Sugata rays of boundless light stream forth,
Conferring all accomplishments and every joy.
Om vajra siddhi hūṃ.

Then, what is to be correctly taught:

Joined perfectly in the union of vowels and consonants,
By the one who holds the union of moon and vajra,
Perfectly complete, he is fully awakened.
Abiding correctly, in the posture of extension and contraction,
At the center of the manifold vajra.
The Joyful One stands before him;
A garland of jewels is placed to his right;
The songstress is to his left;
The dancer of diligent effort abides behind him;
The Summoner is to the east;
The Binder is placed to the south;
The Non-Dual One is to the west;
The Multiplier is placed to the north.

These are the sacred pledges of the Blessed One's perfectly complete body.
This concludes the first chapter, the introductory chapter, of the Great Secret
Tantra of the Noble Acala.

Then the Blessed One entered into the meditative absorption called "Vajra of
the Sacred Pledge of Empowerment." Thereupon from the heart of the Blessed
One rays of light streamed forth, dissolving into the crowns of all the deities,
and they were adorned upon the crown by the lord of the family. Then, what is
to be correctly taught:

Into the excellent great maṇḍala,
The host of offerings was fully absorbed.
Goddesses of form and sound and scent and taste
And touch, beyond measure,
Performed perfect worship with the host of offerings.

Ho! Ho! Unmoved by both extremes,
You accomplish measureless benefit for beings through emanated forms.

Great Terrifier who liberates all wandering beings,
Dancing in delight throughout the three realms of existence,
Drying up the river of conditioned existence and vanquishing the hostile
māras,
Unmoved by the winds of conditioned existence — compassion that does not
waver, protector Acala.

Homage and praise to the majestic, immovable protector!

This is the sacred pledge of the great praise of the Blessed One.

Then, what is to be correctly taught:

In a skull marked with the king's permanence,
Five hooks and so forth are to be placed.
A maṇḍala of wind and fire is set,
Dwelling correctly within the skull.

This is the sacred pledge of the great nectar of the Blessed One.

Then, what is to be correctly taught:

Brahmā, Śakra (Indra), Yama,
The lord of waters, the yakṣas, Viṣṇu, and so forth,
The fire deity, the rākṣasas, the deity of wind,
The spirits and the earth goddess,
The asuras and so forth, along with their retinues — summon them all.

Oṃ akāro mukhaṃ sarvadharmāṇām ādyanutpannatvāt svāhā.

Oṃ khāhi khāhi pheṃ pheṃ svāhā. Nectar, flesh, blood, and so forth — all the
torma offerings (Skt. bali) are to be given.

This concludes the second chapter, the chapter of realization, from the Great
Secret Tantra of the Noble Immovable One (Acalanātha).

Then, what is to be correctly taught:

The sacred maṇḍala of mind
Is to be made four cubits in measure.
Having laid it out on the ground,
The maṇḍala's two encircling borders — long and short —
Are to be drawn with a line cord by one who is skilled.
Having fashioned it in the likeness of a wheel,
It is to be entirely encircled by a vajra garland.

It is to be made four-cornered and four-gated,
Properly endowed with four archways.
In the center, place a great sword.
In the east, place a vajra.
In the south, a jewel garland.
In the west, the Dharma's lute (vīṇā).
In the north, a three-pointed vajra.
At the gates, an iron hook, a noose,
An iron chain, and a bell — these are to be placed by one who is skilled.

This is the sacred pledge of the placement of the great maṇḍala of the Blessed One.

Then, if rain does not fall: upon the top of a four-sided platform, place a silver bowl, and fashion a form made of dough into a triple-tiered lotus. Upon it, set the image of a nāga and anoint it with saffron. At the borders, arrange the syllables Oṃ and Paṃ. Perform a fire offering with white sandalwood. With the application of many colors, definitively summon the nāga's form. If even then the rain does not fall: on a white stone slab, draw an eight-bladed wheel of swords using the juice of the priyangu plant. Take earth from the surface of the ocean, make the nāga's form manifest thereby, anoint it with the juice of garuḍa, and perform a fire offering with sesame oil.

Then, what is to be correctly taught:

Inside a yellow vessel, insert the image of the object of accomplishment and draw the eight-peaked Mount Meru using the sap of a hollow stem. One is to remain concentrated in that. With very sharp iron, fashion a sword one cubit and a half in length. Place it upon a white maṇḍala and recite the mantra for six months. Anoint it with sesame oil, and perform the accomplishment when the moon is seized by a planetary eclipse. One will fly through the sky unimpeded.

The five nectars and the five kinds of flesh — let them dry in the shade. Wrap them with three pieces of iron, face east, and remain in fasting. When the moon is seized by an eclipse, insert it in the mouth. Enter into meditative equipoise and recite it twenty times. Having been placed in the mouth, it will not be apparent to others.

This is the sacred pledge of the great accomplishment (siddhi) of the Blessed One.

Then, what is to be correctly taught:

On a white and round ground surface,
Kindle a fire of white sandalwood
And perform a fire offering with butter of yellow hue —
Great accomplishment will be obtained.
Perform a fire offering with white mustard seed —
The accomplishment of holding the mantra will be obtained.
Perform a fire offering with black sesame —
All misdeeds will be pacified.
Perform a fire offering with dūrvā grass sprouts —
The life-mantra holder's accomplishment will be obtained.
Make stakes (kīla) from acacia wood,
Recite the secret mantra twenty-one times,
And drive them into the desired form —
With joy, accomplishment will be bestowed.

This concludes the third chapter, the chapter of accomplishment, from the Great Secret Tantra of the Noble Immovable One.

Then, the Blessed One, filled with complete joy, gazed upon Mañjuśrī and the others and uttered the sound "Om Āḥ Hūṃ," and became invisible. Then the joyful assembly, no longer beholding their lord, approached from all four directions and made this supplication:

How wondrous, O Blessed One!
Why do you abide in the state of emptiness?
I am Brahmā (Skt. Brahṃā), one of pure conduct, filled with loving-kindness —
Arouse from the nirvāṇa into which you have fully entered!
Alas! O body of great bliss,
Unprolific by any words whatsoever —
I am one of devoted attachment and great compassion.

Who liberates beings completely —
How wondrous, O stainless and pure body!
Do not remain absorbed in the state of emptiness;
Delight in us with great joy!
Declare your compassionate care for the welfare of beings.
How wondrous, O you who accomplish every aim,
O body of pure, stainless wisdom —
So that I may embrace all beings,

Rise up, O sovereign one, in your true form!

Then the Blessed One, filled with complete delight, manifested his body in its full perfection and proclaimed these kings of mantra:

Oṃ Āryācala Hūṃ Phaṭ. Oṃ Vajra Kīli Kīlaya, Sarva Vighnān Bandhaya Hūṃ Phaṭ.

These are the secret mantra and the mantra of the kīla (Skt. kīla, the ritual peg or spike).

Oṃ Namaḥ Samanta Vajrāṇāṃ Vajra Caṇḍa Mahā Roṣaṇa Sphoṭaya, Hūṃ Hūṃ Hūṃ Traṭ Hāṃ, Māṃ Pāṃ Hāṃ Māṃ Taśa Hūṃ, Mama Hūṃ Phaṭ Svāhā.

This is the exceedingly sharp mantra, the one for accomplishing all activities.

Then all those in the assembly came to a thorough understanding of the meaning of the secret mantras.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "the one who turns the wheel of Dharma immediately upon arousing the awakening mind" translates a name or epithet of a figure in the assembly; it may alternatively be a title referring to a specific bodhisattva whose name is this phrase, though in context it reads as a descriptive epithet within a list of attendants.

The verse on Acala's maṇḍala retinue — "Joyful One," "songstress," "dancer of diligent effort," "Summoner," "Binder," "Non-Dual One," and "Multiplier" — are standard offering goddess names in this tantra's maṇḍala system. The rendering follows their literal meanings as given in the Tibetan, since the Sanskrit originals are not supplied in this passage.

The mantra at the close is the well-known formula meaning "The syllable A is the gateway of all phenomena because of their primordial non-arising," here integrated into the ritual as an invocation mantra.

- The term rendered "archways" translates the Tibetan for what are traditionally toraṇa-style gates in maṇḍala architecture; "archways" or "gate-porticoes" are both defensible.

The phrase "holding the mantra" renders the Tibetan for vidyādhara-siddhi, the accomplishment of one who holds or masters a mantra-vidyā; this is a recognized category of tantric attainment.

The final verse's speaker is ambiguous in the text. The suppliant who identifies as "Brahmā, one of pure conduct" and laments the Blessed One's disappearance into emptiness may be a composite voice of the assembly, with Brahmā speaking first; the shift from plural assembly to singular voice is a feature of the genre rather than a textual problem.

"Priyangu" is a plant (*Callicarpa macrophylla*) whose juice is used in ritual contexts; the identification is standard in tantric commentarial literature.

- The assembly's supplication is rendered as verse in keeping with the preceding passage's poetic form. The Tibetan presents the first-person speaker shifting between what appear to be

different members of the assembly speaking in turn, following the dramatic pattern established in the preceding section. The mantras are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan; "Āryācala" likely refers to the deity Acala, the "Immovable One," a wrathful manifestation, and the second mantra series corresponds to the well-known Acala or Caṇḍa Mahāroṣaṇa vidyā found widely in tantric literature. The kīla mantra ("Vajra Kīli Kīlaya") is the seed mantra of Vajrakīlaya (Skt. Vajrakīla), the wrathful deity of the ritual spike; this identification is made explicit by the Tibetan gloss in the text itself.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.